# Footnote

A note at the bottom of the page where its number is.

## One note

The lamp-keepers of the northern coast kept a record of every evening they lit the harbor[1], and the record grew longer than the harbor itself. Most nights the third column stayed empty, and the keepers took pride in that.

## Several notes on a page

The oldest keeper claimed that she could tell the season from the smell of the oil alone[2], and she was seldom wrong. Nobody could say when the first entry was made[3], only that the ink in it had faded to the color of weak tea. When a storm did come, the entries ran past the margin[4] and onto the back of the page.

Under the lamp room stood a cupboard of spare wicks, glass chimneys and one brass bell that nobody remembered buying. A page of the record was ruled into three columns: the hour, the weather, and a line for anything worth remembering. Visitors who read the record in order noticed that the handwriting changed every few years, while the weather never did.

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Keepers who stayed on the coast for many winters learned to read the record the way a sailor reads a chart. A page of the record was ruled into three columns: the hour, the weather, and a line for anything

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[1] The record is kept in the museum at the old customs house, in forty volumes.

[2] Whale oil in winter, colza in spring, and later the paraffin the lighthouse board sent.

[3] The first leaf is lost; the earliest entry that can be read is from the autumn of 1811.

[4] Some are written crosswise over the ruling, and a few *on the back of the page*.

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worth remembering. The last column held what the keepers could not leave out: a ship lost on the bar[5], a child born in the lamp room, or the winter the harbor froze from the pier to the point.

## On the next page

A note keeps to the page of its number. When the notes of a page would crowd out the line they belong to, the line moves to the next page, with its note[6], and the page before it ends a little early.

[5] The brig Alder, in the November gale of 1834; the keeper rang the brass bell until morning.

[6] This note is on the second page, with the number that stands in the line above it.

## A section of its own

The numbers of the notes start over in a section, so the note of this text is the first again[1], and it stands at the bottom of this page.

[1] Numbered 1, though the section before it has six notes.